Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

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- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at: https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

- **`helix`**
- **`helix`** `<file>`
- **`helix`** `<file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- **`helix`** `–help`
- **`hx`** `in some distributions or by alias`

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
        v – enter select mode
        3 – select 3
        w – words
        d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
       wd – delete word
       xc – change line
       %y – yank entire file
```

1.5 Modes

As used in Helix documentation.

```
        : – command
        i – insert
        v – select or extend
        z – view - change view preserving
            selection
        g – goto
        m – match
   Ctrl-w – window
        ␣ – space
     [, ] – unimpaired
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

`u / U`	undo / redo change in linear history
`Alt-u / Alt-U`	move backward / forward in tree history
`:ear / :lat`	move backward / forward in history by step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
`<nn><cmd>`	repeat <cmd> <nn> times
`Esc`	return to normal mode

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

`:wq`	write current buffer and quit
`:wq <file>`	write current buffer to <file> and quit
`:wqa`	write all buffer(s) and quit
`:q`	quit current buffer, exits if last

2.1.2 Files

`:o <file>`	open <file> in new buffer
`:w <file>`	write current buffer to <file>
`:hs <file>`	open/create <file> in new horizontal split
`:vs <file>`	open/create <file> in new vertical split
`␣wf`	open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
`␣wF`	open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
`gf`	open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.
`␣f`	open file picker at LSP workspace root
`␣F`	open file picker at current working directory
`␣g`	open changed file picker

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

`<enter>`	open selected in current view
`Ctrl-s`	open selected in new horizontal split
`Ctrl-v`	open selected in new vertical split

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

`:n`	create new scratch buffer
`:bc`	close current buffer
`:bca`	close all buffers
`:bco`	close all but current buffer
`:bn`	next buffer
`␣b`	open buffer picker
`ga`	go to last accessed/alternate buffer
`gm`	go to last modified/alternate buffer
`gn`	go to next buffer
`gp`	go to previous buffer

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

`␣ws / ␣wv`	split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
`␣wns / ␣wnv`	split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
`␣wq`	close current split
`␣wo`	close all but current split
`␣ww`	next split
`␣wh/j/k/l`	move to buffer left / up / down / right
`␣wH/J/K/L`	swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
`␣wt`	transpose split

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

`Z`	enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
`zz, zc`	align to center
`zt`	align to top
`zb`	align to bottom
`zm`	align to middle horizontally
`zj`	scroll down
`zk`	scroll up

2.1.5 Help

`:tutor`	open tutorial
`␣?`	open command palette

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
 gh, g| – beginning of line
 <nn>g| – column <nn>
     gl – end of line
     gg – top of file
  <nn>G,– line <nn>
 g<nn>g
     ge – bottom of file
     gw – two-char labels on words, label to
          go to word
     g.– to last modification in current file
     gj – down textual line
     gk – up textual line
     gs – first non-white-space char
     gt – top of screen
     gc – middle of screen
     gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
 gd – go to definition
 gy – go to type definition
 gr – go to references
 gi – go to implementation
 ]d – next diagnostic
 [d – prior diagnostic
 ]D – last diagnostic
 [D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
 ]f, [f – to next, prior function
 ]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
 ]T, [T – to next, prior test
 ]a, [a – to next, prior arg
 ]c, [c – to next, prior comment
 ]g, [g – to next, prior change
 ]G, [G – to last, first change
 Alt-e – move to end of parent node in
         syntax tree
 Alt-b – move to start of parent node in
         syntax tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
 Ctrl-b – page up
 Ctrl-f – page down
 Ctrl-u – half page up
 Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
     % – select whole file
Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor
        at end)
Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
Alt-i – shrink selection
     ; – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
 ma<ch> / – match around / inside the
   mi<ch>   object indicated by <ch> below:
     w / W – word / WORD
         p – paragraph
(, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
         m –  closest surround pair
         f – function
         t – type or class
         a – argument/parameter
         c – comment
         T – test
         g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
 w / W – to start of next word / WORD
 e / E – to end of current word / WORD
 b / B – to start of current word / WORD
     x – current line, extend by line
     X – extend to line
Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
    ]p – to next paragraph
    [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax
        node
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
Alt-p – select previous sibling node in
        syntax tree
Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax
        tree
Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax
        tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
      Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
         v – toggle select mode
       Esc – return to normal
         ) – cycle primary selection forward
         ( – cycle primary selection backward
    Alt-,  – remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
   s<regex> – matches become selections
          S – split on match
     Alt-s – split on newlines
  C, Alt-C – add selection below, above
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
          & – align on primary cursor
     Alt-<minus> – merge selections
     Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selections
          , – remove all except primary selection
      Alt-, – remove primary selection
    ( / ) – rotate primary backwards / forwards
  Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content backward / forward
          K – keep selections matching the regex
      Alt-K – remove selections matching the regex
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
          i – before selection
          a – after selection
          I – at start of line
          A – at end of line
          o – add line and insert below cursor
          O – add line and insert above cursor
        Esc – end insert (return to normal)
          . – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
         ]␣ – newline below
         [␣ – newline above
     ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
          d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
      Alt-d – delete, no save
     md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.4 Change

```
          c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
      Alt-c – change, no save
          = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
          > – Indent line(s) containing selection
          < – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
          ~ – change case
          ` – set lowercase
      Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
  ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
         ␣C – Toggle block comment
  ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
     Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
     Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

`J`	join lines in a selection
`Alt-J`	join lines inside selection and select the inserted space
`<under>`	trim whitespace from selection
`:reflow <width>`	wrap selection to <width>, default 80
`:sort`	sort ranges in selection
`:format`	format file using external formatter / language server

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

`y`	selection -> yank buf
`p`	paste yank buf after the cursor
`P`	paste yank buf before the cursor
`␣y`	yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
`␣Y`	yank main selection -> system clipboard
`␣p / ␣P`	paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
`␣R`	replace selection(s) with clipboard
`r<ch>`	replace selection with <ch>
`R`	replace selection with yank buf
`"`	select register to yank to or paste from

2.8 Search

`/<regex>`	search forward for regex
`?<regex>`	search backward for regex
`n, N`	next, previous match
`*`	search for current selection, respect word boundaries
`Alt-*`	search for current selection

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

`"<ch>`	change to reg <ch>
`"<ch>y`	yank into reg <ch>
`"<ch>p`	paste from reg <ch>
`"<ch>R`	replace with reg <ch>

2.10 Macros

`"<ch>Q`	toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
`"<ch>q`	play macro in reg <ch>, default @

2.11 Jumplists

`Ctrl-s`	save current position to jumplist
`Ctrl-i`	move forward in jumplist
`Ctrl-o`	move backwards in jumplist
`␣j`	open jumplist picker

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

`mm`	go to matching delim
`mi<ch>`	match inside delim <ch>
`ma<ch>`	match around delim <ch>
`ms<ch>`	add delim <ch> around selection
`md<ch>`	delete delim <ch> around selection
`mr<ch1><ch2>`	replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

`|`	replace selection(s) with output
`Alt-|`	ignore output
`!`	insert output before each selection(s)
`Alt-!`	append output after each selection(s)
`$`	keep selection(s) where command returned 0

2.14 Approaching an IDE

`␣G`	debug - experimental
`␣k`	show documentation for item under cursor
`␣s`	open document symbol picker
`␣S`	open workspace symbol picker
`␣d`	open document diagnostics picker
`␣D`	open workspace diagnostics picker
`␣r`	rename symbol
`␣a`	apply code action
`␣h`	select symbol references for symbol under cursor

2.15 Editor Configuration

`:config-open`	open the config file
`:config-open-workspace`	open the workspace config file
`:config-reload`	reload the config file

2.16 Miscellaneous

`␣'`	open last picker
`␣/`	open global search in workspace folder picker

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

Ctrl-s	commit undo checkpoint
Ctrl-x	autocomplete
Ctrl-r	insert a register content
Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp>	delete previous word
Alt-d, Alt-<del>	delete next word
Ctrl-u	delete to start of line
Ctrl-k	delete to end of line
Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp>	delete previous char
Ctrl-d, <del>	delete next char
Ctrl-j, <enter>	insert new line
<Up> <Down> <Left> <Right> <PageUp> <PageDown> <Home> <End>	usual meaning but discouraged

3.2 Command Line Editing

Esc, Ctrl-c	close prompt
<enter>	open selected
<tab>	select next completion item
<backtab>	select previous completion item
Alt-b	backward a word
Ctrl-b	backward a char
Alt-f	forward a word
Ctrl-f	forward a char
Ctrl-e	to prompt end
Ctrl-a	to prompt start
Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp>	delete previous word
Alt-d, Ctrl-<del>	delete next word
Ctrl-u	delete to start of line
Ctrl-k	delete to end of line
<bksp>, Ctrl-h	delete previous char
<del>, Ctrl-d	delete next char
Ctrl-s	insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
Ctrl-p	select previous history
Ctrl-n	select next history
Ctrl-r	insert the content of the register selected by following input char

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up>	previous entry
<tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down>	next entry
<Home>	to first entry
<End>	to last entry
Ctrl-u, <PageUp>	page up
Ctrl-d, <PageDown>	page down
<enter>	open selected
Alt-<enter>	open selected in the background without closing the picker
Ctrl-s	open horizontally
Ctrl-v	open vertically
Ctrl-t	toggle preview
Esc, Ctrl-c	close picker

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

Ctrl-u	scroll up
Ctrl-d	scroll down

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p	previous entry
Tab, Ctrl-n	next entry
<enter>	close menu and accept completion
Ctrl-c	close menu and reject completion

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

Alt-p	previous signature
Alt-n	next signature

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- `Ctrl-d` – delete next char **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-d` – delete next char **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-d` – half page down **(2.2.4)**
- `Ctrl-d` – page down **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-d` – scroll down **(3.4)**
- `Ctrl-e` – to prompt end **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-f` – forward a char **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-f` – page down **(2.2.4)**
- `Ctrl-h` – delete previous char **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-h` – delete previous char **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-i` – move forward in jumplist **(2.11)**
- `Ctrl-j` – insert new line **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-k` – delete to end of line **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-k` – delete to end of line **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-n` – next entry **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-n` – next entry **(3.5)**
- `Ctrl-n` – select next history **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-o` – move backwards in jumplist **(2.11)**
- `Ctrl-p` – previous entry **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-p` – previous entry **(3.5)**
- `Ctrl-p` – select previous history **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-r` – insert a register content **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-r` – insert the content of the register selected by following input char **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-s` – commit undo checkpoint **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-s` – insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later) **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-s` – open horizontally **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-s` – open selected in new horizontal split **(2.1.2.1)**
- `Ctrl-s` – save current position to jumplist **(2.11)**
- `Ctrl-t` – toggle preview **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-u` – delete to start of line **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-u` – delete to start of line **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-u` – half page up **(2.2.4)**
- `Ctrl-u` – page up **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-u` – scroll up **(3.4)**
- `Ctrl-v` – open selected in new vertical split **(2.1.2.1)**
- `Ctrl-v` – open vertically **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-w` – delete previous word **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-w` – delete previous word **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-x` – autocomplete **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-x` – decrement the selected number **(2.6.8)**
- `Esc` – close picker **(3.3)**
- `Esc` – close prompt **(3.2)**
- `Esc` – end insert (return to normal) **(2.6.1)**
- `Esc` – return to normal **(2.4)**
- `Esc` – return to normal mode **(2.1)**
- `F<ch>` – to <ch> inclusive (find) **(2.3.5)**
- `I` – at start of line **(2.6.1)**
- `J` – join lines in a selection **(2.6.9)**
- `K` – keep selections matching the regex **(2.5.2)**
- `N` – next, previous match **(2.8)**
- `O` – add line and insert above cursor **(2.6.1)**
- `P` – paste yank buf before the cursor **(2.7)**
- `R` – replace selection with yank buf **(2.7)**
- `S` – split on match **(2.5.1)**
- `Shift-<bksp>` – delete previous char **(3.1)**
- `Shift-<tab>` – previous entry **(3.3)**
- `Shift-Tab` – previous entry **(3.5)**
- `T` – test **(2.3.2)**
- `T<ch>` – to <ch> exclusive (till) **(2.3.5)**
- `Tab` – next entry **(3.5)**
- `X` – extend to line **(2.3.3)**
- `Z` – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc **(2.1.4.1)**
- `[␣` – newline above **(2.6.2)**

- `[` – specified surround pairs **(2.3.2)**
- `[D` – first diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- `[G` – to last, first change **(2.2.3)**
- `[T` – to next, prior test **(2.2.3)**
- `[a` – to next, prior arg **(2.2.3)**
- `[c` – to next, prior comment **(2.2.3)**
- `[d` – prior diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- `[f` – to next, prior function **(2.2.3)**
- `[g` – to next, prior change **(2.2.3)**
- `[p` – to prior paragraph **(2.3.3)**
- `[t` – to next, prior type definition **(2.2.3)**
- `]␣` – newline below **(2.6.2)**
- `]D` – last diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- `]G` – to last, first change **(2.2.3)**
- `]T` – to next, prior test **(2.2.3)**
- `]a` – to next, prior arg **(2.2.3)**
- `]c` – to next, prior comment **(2.2.3)**
- `]d` – next diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- `]f` – to next, prior function **(2.2.3)**
- `]g` – to next, prior change **(2.2.3)**
- `]p` – to next paragraph **(2.3.3)**
- `]t` – to next, prior type definition **(2.2.3)**
- `` ` `` – set lowercase **(2.6.6)**
- `a` – after selection **(2.6.1)**
- `a` – argument/parameter **(2.3.2)**
- `b / B` – to start of current word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
- `c` – comment **(2.3.2)**
- `c` – selection -> yank buf, change selection **(2.6.4)**
- `d` – selection -> yank buf, delete selection **(2.6.3)**
- `e / E` – to end of current word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
- `etc.` – specified surround pairs **(2.3.2)**
- `f` – function **(2.3.2)**
- `f<ch>` – to <ch> inclusive (find) **(2.3.5)**
- `g` – change git hunk **(2.3.2)**
- `g.` – to last modification in current file **(2.2.1)**
- `g<nn>g` – line <nn> **(2.2.1)**
- `ga` – go to last accessed/alternate buffer **(2.1.3)**
- `gb` – bottom of screen **(2.2.1)**
- `gc` – middle of screen **(2.2.1)**
- `gd` – go to definition **(2.2.2)**
- `ge` – bottom of file **(2.2.1)**
- `gf` – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection. **(2.1.2)**
- `gg` – top of file **(2.2.1)**
- `gh` – beginning of line **(2.2.1)**
- `gi` – go to implementation **(2.2.2)**
- `gj` – down textual line **(2.2.1)**
- `gk` – up textual line **(2.2.1)**
- `gl` – end of line **(2.2.1)**
- `gm` – go to last modified/alternate buffer **(2.1.3)**
- `gn` – go to next buffer **(2.1.3)**
- `gp` – go to previous buffer **(2.1.3)**
- `gr` – go to references **(2.2.2)**
- `gs` – first non-white-space char **(2.2.1)**
- `gt` – top of screen **(2.2.1)**
- `gw` – two-char labels on words, label to go to word **(2.2.1)**
- `gy` – go to type definition **(2.2.2)**
- `g|` – beginning of line **(2.2.1)**
- `h/j/k/l` – left / up / down / right **(2.2.1)**
- `i` – before selection **(2.6.1)**
- `m` – closest surround pair **(2.3.2)**
- `ma<ch>` – match around delim <ch> **(2.12)**
- `ma<ch> /` – match around / inside the object
- `mi<ch>` indicated by <ch> below: **(2.3.2)**
- `md<ch>` – delete delim <ch> around selection **(2.12)**
- `md<ch>` – delete delim <ch> around selection **(2.6.3)**
- `mi<ch>` – match inside delim <ch> **(2.12)**
- `mm` – go to matching delim **(2.12)**
- `mr<ch1><ch2>` – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> **(2.12)**
- `mr<ch1><ch2>` – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> **(2.6.4)**
- `ms<ch>` – add delim <ch> around selection **(2.12)**
- `ms<ch>` – add delim <ch> around selection **(2.6.2)**
- `n` – next, previous match **(2.8)**
- `o` – add line and insert below cursor **(2.6.1)**
- `p` – paragraph **(2.3.2)**
- `p` – paste yank buf after the cursor **(2.7)**
- `r<ch>` – replace selection with <ch> **(2.7)**
- `s<regex>` – matches become selections **(2.5.1)**
- `t` – type or class **(2.3.2)**
- `t<ch>` – to <ch> exclusive (till) **(2.3.5)**
- `u / U` – undo / redo change in linear history **(2.1)**
- `v` – toggle select mode **(2.4)**
- `w / W` – to start of next word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
- `w / W` – word / WORD **(2.3.2)**
- `x` – current line, extend by line **(2.3.3)**
- `y` – selection -> yank buf **(2.7)**
- `zb` – align to bottom **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zc` – align to center **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zj` – scroll down **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zk` – scroll up **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zm` – align to middle horizontally **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zt` – align to top **(2.1.4.1)**
- `zz` – align to center **(2.1.4.1)**
- `|` – replace selection(s) with output **(2.13)**
- `~` – change case **(2.6.6)**